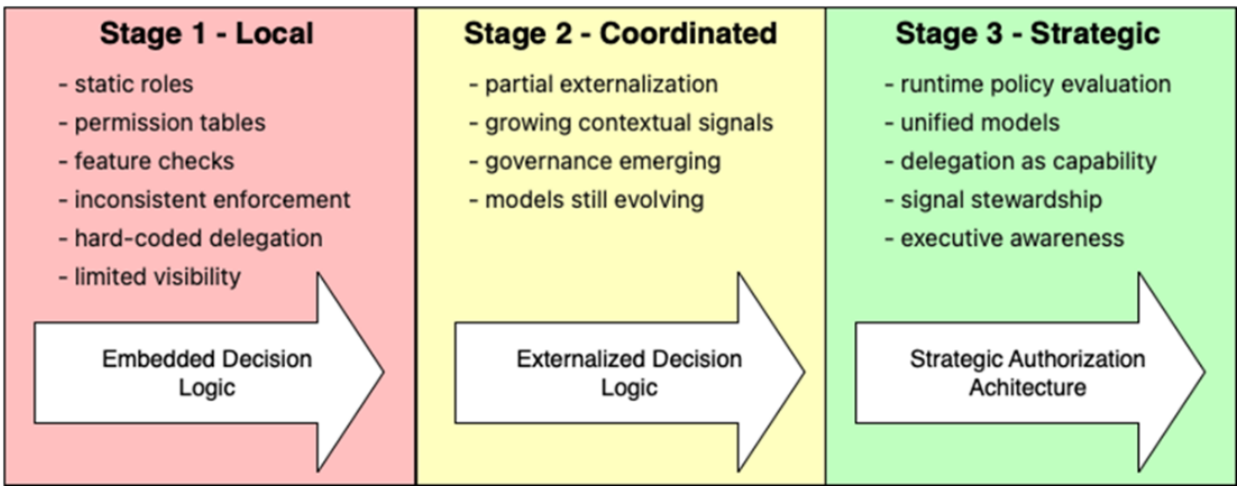


Figure 19.2 Authorization maturity spectrum. Organizations usually evolve from embedding access decisions within individual systems to developing shared decision-making infrastructure. Incremental investments in policy externalization, contextual signals, delegation models, and governance support more consistent automation, collaboration within ecosystems, and strategic trust management.

Many organizations today are in the *Coordinated* stage. They have introduced policy services for specific use cases, started including contextual attributes into access decisions, and set up governance practices to lower risk. These efforts bring meaningful improvements, but decision models often remain fragmented. Different teams may use different methods for policy definition or delegation, making it hard to reason about authority consistently across the organization.

Progress beyond this stage doesn't require a wholesale transformation. Instead, it involves a consistent focus on already emerging patterns. By continuing to externalize decision logic, unify policy models, and enhance signal governance, organizations can incrementally develop the infrastructure needed to manage trust intentionally. As ACME’s experience shows, strategic authorization capability is rarely developed all at once. It is built through incremental choices that align architecture, governance, and organizational understanding.

19.6 A practical path forward

By the time organizations recognize authorization as a growth constraint, they often have already started improving it. Policies are externalized in some systems. Contextual signals are being incorporated into decision-